PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Steyr-Puch Pinzgauer 710 / 712

1971–1985 · 710M · 710K · 712M · 712K

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Hunt rust where the Alps hide**
  The SDP pre-purchase checklist lists the spots: both bottom corners of the air tunnel (sound-deadening foam holds water), the fuel filler neck, the doors (seams, bottoms and inside the window channels), the footwells under the diamond plates, behind the wooden rub rails, the bedside-to-tub seams and the rear door. Owners add the battery and tool boxes and the heat exchanger. Shiny paint over these areas proves nothing.

- [ ] **Check the spring cups and swivel balls**
  The upper spring cups rust through and make an ugly repair, so check them along with the limiting straps. Flaking or pitted plating on the front swivel balls is, in the SDP checklist's words, 'a costly repair.'

- [ ] **Look for red flakes in the fuel filter**
  Red flakes mean the fuel tank's lining is peeling. The checklist says 'be very careful!' and owners on the Portal Hub still ask about tanks that need stripping and relining.

- [ ] **Run a compression test**
  The absolute numbers matter less than consistency. The SDP guide accepts 120–160 psi as long as the cylinders are within about 10 psi of each other, and warns that cylinder 4 (the rearmost) can have overheated. Some owners also do a leak-down test and look inside the oil filler tube for yellow, greasy residue.

- [ ] **Engage everything**
  On a test drive, try low and high range, front drive and both lockers. The SDP guide notes that disengaging sometimes takes a few left-right turns, which is normal. A locker that won't engage usually points to the hydraulics: old fluid, cracked rubber elbows or a seized slave bleeder.

- [ ] **Get under it with a creeper**
  Look for leaks at the portals, diffs, gearbox and transfer case. Some weeping is normal on a 40-year-old truck. Check for torn axle boots, and with the transfer case in neutral, feel for excessive backlash in the driveline. Oil inside a brake drum means a leaking wheel-drive seal.

- [ ] **Drive it at speed**
  If it shakes, engage front drive. If the vibration stops, suspect driveshaft balance. If it doesn't, the wheels were probably never balanced: the SDP checklist says the Swiss didn't balance them. The rims are lug-centric, so a tire shop needs an adapter. Owners also describe a low rumble from the flexible front driveshaft that grows with mileage.

- [ ] **Test the 24-volt electrics and the canvas**
  Open the black distribution box under the right rear corner and check for corrosion. Then check the dash breakers, the fuel and speed gauges (they can stick at zero or full) and the wiper motor. Look over the tarps too: replacing UV-damaged canvas is expensive.

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **710 vs 712**
  Count the axles. The 710 is the 4×4 on a 2,200 mm wheelbase with rear coil springs. The 712 is the 6×6, with a leaf-sprung rear bogie on a 2,000 + 980 mm wheelbase.
- [ ] **Body codes**
  M is the soft top with rear bench seats, K the hardtop station wagon, T the flatbed and AMB the ambulance (AMB-Y, or AMB-S with an air-portable shelter). On the 712 there are also W (workshop), DK (crew cab), FW (fire truck) and FLA.
- [ ] **Petrol 710/712 vs Turbo D 716/718**
  The 710/712 has the air-cooled 2.5-liter petrol four, a five-speed manual, drum brakes and narrower tires. The 716/718 (from 1985) has a water-cooled VW turbodiesel six, disc brakes, a slightly wider track, bigger tires and an optional automatic.
- [ ] **Swiss vs Austrian trucks**
  Swiss trucks have a single amber bulb for turn and brake plus a red tail lamp. Austrian trucks have amber turn signals with separate red brake and tail lamps. Swiss 710K radio command trucks (Funkkommandowagen) have their own wiring.
- [ ] **Engine**
  Check the engine plate and bore. The standard engine is 2,499 cc (92 × 94 mm). Late 712s, mostly ambulances, can have the 2.7-liter air-cooled four.

NOTES

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